

# Values-Led Problem Statement — Bridging the Tokenization Gap in African LLMs via SuperBPE

Challenge 1 submission · Team Manda · TRI AI Cohort 10 · Project 3

| Field   | Entry                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|---------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Team    | Team Manda — Abdurrazaq Khidir Olalekan, Adetayo Tella, Arturo Espinosa Vargas, Ayomide Adeduro, Boluwatife Odunlami, Chitom Uzokwe, Lawrence Adagbon, Surajo Nuhu Umar, Zakaria Tibtiba. No assigned mentor. |
| Project | Bridging the Tokenization Gap in African LLMs via SuperBPE                                                                                                                                                    |

## Problem statement

Millions of African-language speakers — students, small business owners, educators, and communities preserving endangered languages — receive slower, costlier, and less accurate AI experiences than English speakers, simply because today's AI systems misread the structure of their languages. This gap deepens digital inequality and risks pushing speakers away from their own languages online, eroding linguistic diversity across the continent. Our team is building a solution that helps AI understand African languages the way they're actually spoken, preserving meaning rather than fragmenting it. Guided by equity, cultural respect, inclusion, and accountability, we are working directly with native speakers to ensure our solution reflects real community needs rather than technical assumptions. We hope this work gives African-language speakers AI experiences on par with what English speakers already enjoy — more affordable, more accurate, and more respectful of the languages and cultures they carry.